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Literary Texts as Pedagogical Mediators in Russian as a Foreign Language Education: An Integrated Conceptual Framework for Developing Intercultural Communicative Competence in Iranian HigherEducation

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Abstract

The growing emphasis on intercultural communication has reshaped foreign language education, shifting focus from linguistic knowledge to effective cross-cultural communication. Literary texts are recognized as authentic resources exposing learners to linguistic, cultural, historical, and ideological dimensions of the target language. Although studies highlight literature's benefits for vocabulary, reading, cultural awareness, critical thinking, and motivation, research has rarely explained how literary engagement fosters integrated intercultural communicative competence (ICC) in Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) contexts. This conceptual paper proposes an integrated framework conceptualizing literary texts as pedagogical mediators that support simultaneous development of linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. Drawing on ICC theory, Sociocultural Theory, literature-based teaching, language-and-culture studies, and CEFR mediation, the framework introduces Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as the mechanism linking literary engagement with ICC. Literary discourse is viewed as an active medium for meaning construction, cultural negotiation, and reflection. The study offers theoretically grounded propositions for future research and discusses implications for curriculum, teacher education, and assessment in Iranian higher education. By integrating fragmented theories into a coherent model, it advances RFL pedagogy and supports literature-based intercultural language education.

Keywords: Russian as a Foreign Language, literary texts, pedagogical mediation, intercultural communicative competence, conceptual framework

Introduction

The growing interconnectedness of contemporary societies has transformed the objectives of foreign language education. Beyond developing linguistic proficiency, language programs are increasingly expected to prepare learners for meaningful intercultural communication by fostering the knowledge, skills, attitudes, and critical awareness required to engage with diverse cultural perspectives (Byram, 1997, 2021; Council of Europe, 2020). Consequently, intercultural communicative competence (ICC) has become a central goal of language education. This shift has encouraged educators to reconsider the role of authentic cultural resources in language learning. Among these resources, literary texts occupy a distinctive position because they combine authentic language with culturally embedded meanings, multiple perspectives, and opportunities for critical interpretation (Carter & Long, 1991; Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993). Unlike simplified instructional materials, literature exposes learners to the complexity of language in use while encouraging reflection on cultural values, identities, and social experiences.

Research has shown that literature can support vocabulary development, reading comprehension, learner motivation, intercultural awareness, and critical thinking (Collie & Slater, 1987; Hall, 2015; Paran, 2008). Nevertheless, much of this research has focused on documenting educational outcomes rather than explaining the theoretical mechanisms through which literary engagement contributes to intercultural competence. As a result, literature often remains a supplementary component of language curricula instead of being integrated into competence-oriented pedagogical models. This issue is particularly relevant to Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) education. While communicative approaches have become increasingly influential, literature is frequently employed either for linguistic analysis or cultural enrichment rather than as a systematic means of developing intercultural communicative competence (Azimov & Shchukin, 2009; Shchukin, 2015). Consequently, a coherent theoretical framework explaining the pedagogical role of literary texts in RFL instruction remains underdeveloped.

To address this need, the present conceptual paper proposes an integrated framework that conceptualizes literary texts as pedagogical mediators supporting the development of Intercultural Communicative Competence. Drawing upon Intercultural Communicative Competence theory, Sociocultural Theory, language-and-culture studies, literature-based language teaching, and mediation-oriented language education, the study introduces Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as the mechanism linking literary engagement with intercultural learning. By integrating these complementary perspectives,

the article seeks to provide a theory-building contribution that informs future empirical research, curriculum development, and literature-based pedagogy in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language education.

2. Research Gap and Purpose

Although the educational value of literary texts in foreign language learning has been widely recognized, existing scholarship has primarily documented their contributions to language proficiency, reading comprehension, cultural awareness, learner motivation, and critical thinking (Carter & Long, 1991; Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993; Paran, 2008). Comparatively less attention has been devoted to explaining the theoretical mechanisms through which literary engagement promotes Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC), particularly in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) education.

Research on communicative language teaching has established communicative competence as a central objective of language education (Canale & Swain, 1980; Hymes, 1972; Richards & Rodgers, 2014). More recent scholarship has extended this perspective by emphasizing intercultural competence as an essential outcome of foreign language learning (Byram, 1997, 2021; Deardorff, 2006). Despite these developments, literature-based language teaching and intercultural language education have largely evolved as parallel research traditions. As a result, relatively few conceptual models explain how authentic literary texts facilitate the integrated development of linguistic, intercultural, and interpretive competencies.

Similarly, Sociocultural Theory explains learning as a mediated process in which language and cultural artifacts support cognitive development (Lantolf & Thorne, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978), while the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: Companion Volume recognizes mediation as a core communicative activity in language education (Council of Europe, 2020). However, neither perspective explicitly conceptualizes literary texts as pedagogical mediators capable of supporting competence-oriented foreign language instruction.

This theoretical gap is particularly evident in RFL education, where literary texts are frequently employed for language practice or cultural enrichment rather than as a coherent framework for developing intercultural communicative competence (Azimov & Shchukin, 2009; Safonova, 2014; Shchukin, 2015). Consequently, an integrated

theoretical model that explains the educational function of literature within competence-based RFL instruction remains underdeveloped.

To address this gap, the present conceptual paper proposes an integrated framework positioning literary texts as pedagogical mediators in university-level RFL education. Drawing upon Intercultural Communicative Competence theory, Sociocultural Theory, language-and-culture studies, literature-based language teaching, and mediation-oriented language education, the study introduces Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as a conceptual mechanism explaining how literary engagement simultaneously promotes linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation.

Accordingly, the objectives of this study are threefold:

1. To synthesize relevant theoretical perspectives into a coherent conceptual framework for literature-mediated RFL education.

2. To conceptualize literary texts as pedagogical mediators that facilitate competence-oriented language learning.

3. To propose Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as a theoretical construct linking literary engagement with the development of Intercultural Communicative Competence.

3. Definitions of Key Concepts

To ensure conceptual clarity, this study defines the key constructs underpinning the proposed framework as interrelated components of literature-mediated foreign language learning. Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC) refers to the ability to communicate effectively and appropriately across linguistic and cultural contexts. Building on communicative competence (Canale & Swain, 1980; Hymes, 1972), Byram (1997, 2021) defines ICC as the integration of attitudes, knowledge, interpretive and interactional skills, and critical cultural awareness. In this study, ICC represents the intended outcome of literature-mediated Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) instruction. Literary texts are authentic cultural artifacts that combine linguistic, cultural, and aesthetic meanings within realistic communicative contexts (Carter & Long, 1991; Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993). Their dialogic nature (Bakhtin, 1981) and readers' active role in meaning-making (Iser, 1978) encourage learners to interpret language beyond its literal level and develop intercultural understanding through reflection and dialogue.

Pedagogical mediation refers to instructional processes that support knowledge construction through interaction with texts, teachers, and peers. Drawing on Sociocultural Theory (Lantolf & Thorne, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978) and the CEFR Companion Volume (Council of Europe, 2020), it involves interpreting information, negotiating meaning, and facilitating collaborative learning. Within this framework, literary texts function as the primary mediating tool. Integrated Competence Development (ICD), the central construct of this study, describes the reciprocal development of linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. These dimensions evolve simultaneously through literary engagement, reinforcing one another in a unified learning process.

Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) refers to the teaching and learning of Russian by non-native speakers in formal educational settings. Contemporary RFL pedagogy emphasizes communicative competence, intercultural awareness, authentic language use, and the inseparable relationship between language and culture (Azimov & Shchukin, 2009; Safonova, 2014; Shchukin, 2015; Vereshchagin & Kostomarov, 2005). Together, these concepts constitute a coherent theoretical model in which literary texts mediate Integrated Competence Development, ultimately fostering Intercultural Communicative Competence in university-level RFL education.

4. Theoretical Foundations

The proposed conceptual framework integrates complementary theoretical perspectives to explain the relationship between language, culture, literature, and learning. Rather than relying on a single theory, it combines Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC), Sociocultural Theory (SCT), language-and-culture studies, literature-based language teaching, and mediation-oriented language education to explain how literary texts facilitate intercultural language learning. Intercultural Communicative Competence extends communicative competence by emphasizing learners' ability to communicate appropriately across linguistic and cultural contexts (Byram, 1997, 2021). Its core dimensions—attitudes, knowledge, interpretive and interactional skills, and critical cultural awareness—have been further conceptualized as a dynamic developmental process integrating knowledge, skills, attitudes, and behavior (Deardorff, 2006; Liddicoat & Scarino, 2013). Within the present framework, ICC represents the intended educational outcome of literature-mediated language learning.

Sociocultural Theory views learning as a socially mediated process in which knowledge is constructed through interaction with language, cultural artifacts, and others (Vygotsky,

1978; Lantolf, 2000; Lantolf & Thorne, 2006). Central to this perspective is mediation, whereby cultural tools shape cognitive development. In the proposed framework, literary texts function as mediational artifacts that support learners in constructing linguistic and cultural meaning through guided reading, discussion, and reflection. This perspective aligns with language-and-culture studies, which regard language and culture as inseparable and emphasize that language both reflects and constructs cultural meaning (Kramsch, 1993, 1998). Literary texts provide culturally authentic and symbolically rich contexts that encourage learners to move beyond literal comprehension toward intercultural interpretation.

Research on literature-based language teaching consistently shows that literary texts promote language development, cultural awareness, learner motivation, and critical thinking by exposing learners to authentic discourse and encouraging active interpretation (Carter & Long, 1991; Collie & Slater, 1987; Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993; Paran, 2008). While these studies demonstrate the educational value of literature, they provide limited explanation of the mechanisms underlying competence development. The concept of mediation, as defined in the CEFR Companion Volume (Council of Europe, 2020), offers this explanatory link by viewing mediation as the facilitation of understanding between texts, individuals, and cultures through interpretation, collaboration, and meaning negotiation. Building on this perspective, the present study conceptualizes literary texts not only as cultural artifacts but also as pedagogical mediators that create opportunities for collaborative interpretation, intercultural dialogue, and reflective meaning-making. Taken together, these theoretical perspectives form a coherent framework in which literary texts mediate the integrated development of linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation, ultimately fostering Intercultural Communicative Competence in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language education.

5. Relationship to Existing Models

The proposed conceptual framework builds on established theories in language education while offering an integrated explanation of how literary texts contribute to intercultural language learning in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) education. Rather than replacing existing models, it synthesizes their complementary insights into a coherent conceptual framework.

The framework adopts Byram's (1997, 2021) model of Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC) as its primary educational objective, while extending it by explaining how intercultural competence develops through literary engagement. Literary texts are conceptualized as pedagogical mediators through which learners construct linguistic knowledge, interpret cultural meanings, and develop intercultural competence. This perspective complements Sociocultural Theory, which views learning as a socially mediated process shaped by language and cultural artifacts (Vygotsky, 1978; Lantolf, 2000; Lantolf & Thorne, 2006). Whereas SCT emphasizes mediation as a general learning mechanism, the proposed framework identifies literary texts as mediational tools that foster collaborative interpretation, reflective learning, and intercultural dialogue.

The framework also builds on language-and-culture studies, which regard language and culture as inseparable and emphasize the interpretation of culturally embedded meanings (Kramsch, 1993, 1998). Literary texts provide the pedagogical context in which learners connect linguistic forms with cultural interpretation. Likewise, research on literature-based language teaching has demonstrated literature's contribution to language development, cultural awareness, learner motivation, and critical thinking (Carter & Long, 1991; Collie & Slater, 1987; Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993; Paran, 2008). The present framework extends this tradition by introducing Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as the mechanism through which literary engagement simultaneously promotes linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation.

The framework is also consistent with the CEFR Companion Volume (Council of Europe, 2020), which defines mediation as a core communicative activity facilitating understanding between texts, individuals, and cultures. However, it broadens this perspective by conceptualizing pedagogical mediation as an instructional process in which literary texts actively support collaborative meaning-making and intercultural learning, rather than treating mediation solely as a learner competence.

Overall, the proposed framework contributes to existing models in four ways: it reconceptualizes literary texts as pedagogical mediators, introduces Integrated Competence Development as the mechanism linking literary engagement to learning outcomes, integrates major theoretical traditions into a unified model for RFL education, and shifts the emphasis from describing the benefits of literature to explaining the processes through which literature fosters Intercultural Communicative Competence.

6. The Proposed Conceptual Framework

The proposed conceptual framework explains how literary texts contribute to the development of Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC) in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) education. Drawing on the theoretical perspectives discussed earlier, it conceptualizes literary texts as pedagogical mediators that facilitate the integrated development of linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. Rather than viewing these competencies as separate outcomes, the framework considers them mutually reinforcing dimensions of a continuous learning process.

The framework is based on the assumption that authentic literary texts, through pedagogical mediation, promote Integrated Competence Development (ICD), which ultimately fosters ICC. This perspective shifts attention from the instructional value of literature itself to the learning processes that literary engagement makes possible.

Literary texts provide authentic linguistic and culturally embedded contexts in which learners engage with language, perspectives, identities, and social experiences (Kramsch, 1993; Vygotsky, 1978). Guided by Sociocultural Theory and the CEFR Companion Volume (Council of Europe, 2020; Lantolf & Thorne, 2006), pedagogical mediation encourages learners to interpret meanings, compare perspectives, justify interpretations, and construct understanding collaboratively rather than receive knowledge passively.

Within this framework, Integrated Competence Development (ICD) functions as the central explanatory mechanism linking literary engagement to ICC. It encompasses the reciprocal development of linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. Progress in each dimension strengthens the others, creating an iterative process in which reading, discussion, reflection, and interpretation continuously reinforce language learning.

Consistent with Byram's (1997, 2021) model, ICC represents the ultimate educational outcome and is understood as the ability to communicate effectively and appropriately across cultures through the integration of knowledge, skills, attitudes, and critical cultural awareness. In the proposed framework, this competence develops gradually through sustained literary engagement supported by pedagogical mediation.

Table 1

The Proposed Conceptual Framework

Input	Mediating Process	Central Mechanism	Final Outcome
Authentic Literary Texts	Pedagogical Mediation	Integrated Competence Development (Linguistic Competence + Intercultural Understanding + Critical Interpretation)	Intercultural Communicative Competence

Although presented sequentially, the relationships are reciprocal rather than linear, with learners continuously moving between interpretation, interaction, reflection, and communication. By reconceptualizing literary texts as pedagogical mediators and introducing Integrated Competence Development as the mechanism linking literary engagement to ICC, the framework provides a unified theoretical model for RFL education and a foundation for future empirical research, curriculum development, and instructional practice.

7. Theoretical Propositions

The conceptual framework presented in the previous section explains the relationships among literary texts, pedagogical mediation, Integrated Competence Development (ICD), and Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC). To strengthen its explanatory value and provide a basis for future empirical research, the framework is translated into a set of theoretical propositions. Unlike statistical hypotheses, these propositions specify expected conceptual relationships among the constructs and provide directions for subsequent quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods research (Jaakkola, 2020; MacInnis, 2011).

Proposition 1 (P1). Authentic literary texts facilitate learning by functioning as pedagogical mediators rather than merely as instructional materials. Building on literature-based pedagogy (Carter & Long, 1991; Lazar, 1993) and Sociocultural Theory

(Lantolf & Thorne, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978), this proposition argues that literary engagement promotes active interpretation, meaning negotiation, and reflection.

Proposition 2 (P2). Pedagogical mediation through literary engagement simultaneously promotes linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. Instead of developing independently, these competencies evolve through a shared educational process during learners' interaction with literary discourse (Hall, 2015; Paran, 2008).

Proposition 3 (P3). Linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation develop through reciprocal rather than linear relationships. Growth in each dimension supports the others, making competence development an iterative process of interpretation, reflection, and communication.

Proposition 4 (P4). Integrated Competence Development serves as the principal mechanism through which literary engagement contributes to Intercultural Communicative Competence. Consistent with Byram's (1997, 2021) multidimensional model of ICC, the framework proposes that linguistic, intercultural, and interpretive competencies collectively foster intercultural communication.

Proposition 5 (P5). Literature-based pedagogy contributes to educational outcomes extending beyond language proficiency, including reflective judgment, intercultural sensitivity, and perspective-taking. These outcomes are conceptualized as components of Integrated Competence Development rather than isolated instructional benefits (Collie & Slater, 1987; Hall, 2015; Paran, 2008).

Proposition 6 (P6). The effectiveness of literature-mediated competence development depends on instructional design, teacher expertise, learner engagement, and educational context. Accordingly, pedagogical mediation is expected to be shaped by contextual factors, including text selection, classroom interaction, and opportunities for collaborative interpretation (Council of Europe, 2020; Liddicoat & Scarino, 2013).

Collectively, these propositions transform the conceptual framework into a theory-building model that can guide future empirical research. They provide a basis for examining the mediating role of pedagogical mediation, operationalizing and measuring Integrated Competence Development, investigating the reciprocal relationships among competencies, evaluating the influence of instructional variables, and testing the framework across different educational contexts. As conceptually derived propositions,

they are intended to guide empirical validation rather than represent statistically tested conclusions.

8. Pedagogical Implications

The proposed framework has important implications for curriculum design, language instruction, teacher education, materials development, assessment, and learning environments in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) programs. By conceptualizing literary texts as pedagogical mediators, it repositions literature from a supplementary resource to a central component of competence-oriented language education.

From a curricular perspective, literary texts should be systematically integrated across proficiency levels, with selection based not only on linguistic difficulty but also on cultural authenticity, thematic relevance, and opportunities for intercultural reflection (Brown, 2007; Richards, 2006). Classroom practice should emphasize learner-centered activities, including collaborative discussion, reflective writing, problem-solving, and literary interpretation, enabling learners to construct meaning through interaction rather than passively receive information (Lantolf & Thorne, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978).

The framework also highlights the need for teacher education that extends beyond linguistic expertise. Teachers should be prepared to facilitate literary interpretation, intercultural dialogue, collaborative learning, and reflective discussion while integrating literature into competence-based language teaching (Liddicoat & Scarino, 2013; Richards & Rodgers, 2014). Similarly, instructional materials should combine authentic literary texts with activities that encourage interpretation, cultural comparison, collaborative meaning-making, and engagement with multiple perspectives rather than factual comprehension alone (Tomlinson, 2013).

Assessment should adopt an integrated view of competence by evaluating not only linguistic accuracy but also literary interpretation, intercultural reflection, mediation, and analytical writing, consistent with competence-oriented language education (Council of Europe, 2020). At the same time, effective implementation requires learning environments that promote dialogue, learner autonomy, collaboration, and reflective inquiry, recognizing that meaningful learning emerges through interaction with teachers, peers, and cultural artifacts (Williams & Burden, 1997).

Overall, the framework positions literature as a core pedagogical resource for developing linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, critical interpretation, and ultimately Intercultural Communicative Competence. It therefore provides practical guidance for the design of curricula, teaching practices, instructional materials, assessment, and teacher preparation in university-level RFL education.

9. Discussion

This conceptual paper proposed an integrated framework explaining how literary texts contribute to the development of Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC) in university-level Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) education. Although previous studies have consistently demonstrated the educational benefits of literature, they have generally emphasized instructional outcomes rather than the theoretical processes through which those outcomes are achieved. The proposed framework addresses this gap by integrating established theories of language learning into a coherent model centered on pedagogical mediation and Integrated Competence Development (ICD).

A central contribution of the framework is the reconceptualization of literary texts as pedagogical mediators. Traditional communicative approaches have emphasized authentic communication and meaningful interaction as foundations of language learning (Richards & Rodgers, 2014). The present framework extends this perspective by arguing that literary texts provide authentic linguistic input while simultaneously mediating cultural interpretation, reflective inquiry, and collaborative meaning-making. Consequently, literature becomes an active component of competence development rather than a supplementary reading resource.

The framework also contributes to intercultural language education by offering a theoretical explanation of how literary engagement supports ICC. Previous models have identified intercultural knowledge, attitudes, skills, and critical cultural awareness as essential educational objectives (Byram, 1997, 2021; Byram et al., 2001; Sercu, 2005). However, relatively limited attention has been devoted to explaining the pedagogical processes through which these dimensions develop. The concept of Integrated Competence Development addresses this issue by proposing that linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation evolve simultaneously through sustained engagement with literary discourse.

Furthermore, the framework strengthens sociocultural interpretations of language learning by emphasizing mediation as a collaborative process rather than an individual cognitive activity. Through guided discussion, interpretation, and reflection, learners negotiate meanings, compare cultural perspectives, and construct shared understanding. These processes are consistent with contemporary perspectives on teacher learning and classroom interaction, which view knowledge construction as socially situated and dialogic (Freeman & Johnson, 1998; Lantolf & Thorne, 2006).

From the perspective of RFL education, the framework also responds to continuing calls for closer integration of language and culture. Research in intercultural language education has emphasized that cultural learning requires opportunities for reflection, comparison, and interpretation rather than the transmission of factual information alone (Moran, 2001; Sercu, 2005). Literary texts provide precisely such opportunities by presenting culturally situated narratives that encourage learners to interpret diverse perspectives and examine their own assumptions.

Finally, the proposed framework contributes to conceptual research by synthesizing insights from Intercultural Communicative Competence theory, Sociocultural Theory, literature-based language teaching, and mediation-oriented language education into a unified explanatory model. Rather than introducing an alternative theory, it demonstrates how these complementary perspectives can be integrated to explain literature-mediated competence development in university-level RFL instruction.

Overall, the framework provides a coherent theoretical foundation for future empirical research, curriculum development, teacher education, and literature-based pedagogy. By positioning literary texts as pedagogical mediators and conceptualizing competence development as an integrated process, the model offers a theoretically grounded explanation of how literature can support intercultural language learning in higher education.

10. Theoretical Contribution

The present study contributes to the literature on Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) education by proposing a novel conceptual framework that integrates previously disconnected theoretical perspectives into a coherent explanation of literature-mediated language learning. Rather than treating literary texts as supplementary instructional

resources, the framework reconceptualizes them as pedagogical mediators that actively facilitate learners' construction of linguistic, cultural, and interpretive knowledge.

The primary theoretical contribution lies in the introduction of Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as a conceptual mechanism explaining how literary engagement simultaneously promotes linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. While previous studies have documented positive educational outcomes associated with literature-based instruction (Hall, 2015; Paran, 2008), they have generally examined these outcomes independently. The proposed framework explains their reciprocal interaction within a unified developmental process, thereby offering a more comprehensive account of competence development.

A second contribution concerns the extension of mediation theory. Although the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: Companion Volume (Council of Europe, 2020) conceptualizes mediation as a communicative activity performed by language users, the present study broadens this perspective by introducing pedagogical mediation as an instructional process facilitated by literary texts. This extension highlights literature as an active educational medium through which learners negotiate meanings, compare cultural perspectives, and collaboratively construct understanding.

Finally, the study contributes to theory building by integrating Intercultural Communicative Competence theory (Byram, 1997, 2021), Sociocultural Theory (Lantolf & Thorne, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978), language-and-culture studies (Kramsch, 1993, 1998), literature-based pedagogy (Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993), and mediation-oriented language education (Council of Europe, 2020) into a unified conceptual model. In doing so, it provides a theoretically grounded foundation for future empirical research and curriculum development in literature-based RFL education.

11. Limitations

As a conceptual paper, this study is subject to several limitations. First, the proposed framework has not been empirically tested; therefore, the relationships among its constructs remain theoretical and require validation through quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods research.

Second, the framework has been developed primarily with reference to university-level Russian as a Foreign Language education in Iran. Although its theoretical foundations are broadly applicable, educational systems, learner characteristics, and instructional contexts may influence the transferability of the model to other settings.

Third, the framework synthesizes several established theoretical traditions. While this interdisciplinary approach strengthens conceptual integration, it may also overlook context-specific variables such as learners' prior intercultural experiences, teachers' professional competencies, institutional resources, and curriculum constraints. Future empirical studies should therefore investigate the influence of these contextual factors on literature-mediated competence development.

12. Future Research

The framework proposed in this study opens several avenues for future investigation. First, empirical studies should examine the relationships proposed in the conceptual model and evaluate whether pedagogical mediation significantly contributes to the development of intercultural communicative competence in RFL classrooms.

Second, future research should operationalize Integrated Competence Development (ICD) by developing reliable measurement instruments capable of assessing its linguistic, intercultural, and interpretive dimensions. Such instruments would enable researchers to examine the reciprocal relationships among these competencies and evaluate the explanatory power of the proposed model.

Third, comparative studies conducted across different educational systems, proficiency levels, and foreign language contexts may determine the broader applicability of the framework. Finally, longitudinal classroom research could investigate how sustained engagement with literary texts influences competence development over time and identify instructional practices that maximize the effectiveness of literature-mediated pedagogy.

13. Conclusion

The increasing importance of intercultural communication has transformed the objectives of foreign language education, requiring theoretical models that explain not only what

learners should achieve but also how meaningful competence development occurs. Responding to this need, the present conceptual paper proposed an integrated framework that positions literary texts as pedagogical mediators within university-level Russian as a Foreign Language education.

Drawing upon Intercultural Communicative Competence theory, Sociocultural Theory, language-and-culture studies, literature-based language teaching, and mediation-oriented language education, the study introduced Integrated Competence Development (ICD) as the central mechanism linking literary engagement with intercultural communicative competence. The framework argues that authentic literary discourse simultaneously promotes linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation through socially mediated processes of meaning construction.

Beyond synthesizing existing theoretical perspectives, the proposed framework offers a new conceptualization of literature as an active educational medium rather than a supplementary instructional resource. By identifying pedagogical mediation as the mechanism through which literary engagement supports competence development, the study contributes to theory building in applied linguistics and Russian as a Foreign Language pedagogy.

Although empirical validation remains necessary, the framework provides a coherent foundation for future research, curriculum design, teacher education, and literature-based instructional innovation. More broadly, it demonstrates that literary texts can play a central role in preparing learners for meaningful intercultural communication in increasingly interconnected educational and professional environments.

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